3. Justification of Inscription

3.A Criteria under which inscription is proposed

Criterion (iii) requires that the nominated properties should bear a unique or at least exceptional testimony to a cultural tradition or to a civilization which is living or which has disappeared; accordingly, the proposed serial nomination of the sites and landscapes of the Galilee related to the life and ministry of Jesus and the Apostles bears unique testimony to the historical and geographical context of the ancient gospel traditions and to the evolving pilgrimage traditions of Christianity.

The New Testament describes the Galilee of the early 1st century as the main geographical focus of the ministry of Jesus: tracing the journeys he took among the inland villages and describing the places on the shores of the Sea of Galilee where he gathered his disciples and preached and healed the poor and lowly. Some of the sites in this proposed serial nomination are specifically mentioned in the scriptures: Nazareth, Cana, Chorazin. Other sites included in the nomination, such as Tabgha, the Mount of the Beatitudes,Mt. Tabor and Magdala, are not directly identified or mentioned by name in the gospels, but have been venerated by Christian pilgrims since the Byzantine period as sanctified places along a route on which they reverently "walked in the footsteps of Jesus".

Archaeological remains from the early Roman period, in addition to the historical sources, attest to the cultural context within which Jesus and his followers lived and established the basic moral and ethical ideals of Christianity. These include the excavated town center of Magdala, the grotto and structures of the village of Nazareth, and the “House of Peter" in Capernaum. Later remains, such as Byzantine and Crusader churches at the holy places, testify to the continuity of pilgrimage traditions to those sites.

As generation after generation of pilgrims returned to the same venerated places, they added new layers of meaning, and left their mark on the physical character of the sites. Around the grotto of the house of Mary in Nazareth, for example, the remains of the Roman period village, of the Byzantine church, and the massive walls and columns of the Crusader basilica can all be seen, all of them integrated into the present-day complex. Similar examples of historical layering over the centuries exist in Capernaum, and at Tabgha, in the Church of the Primacy of St. Peter and the Church of the Multiplication of the Loaves and Fishes.

The landscapes of the Galilee are more than merely the visual backdrop of the events described in the Gospels; they also form part of their message, as the physical places where divine revelation occurred. The powerful spiritual connection between the scriptures and the landscape is also reflected in the numerous references in the parables and the teachings of Jesus to the Galilee’s typical agricultural regime and natural environment. Indeed, some have referred to the landscape of the Galilee as a 'fifth gospel' (Renan 1863) that gives material form to the abstract concepts of the biblical texts. Indeed, a closer familiarity with the landscape and environment associated with the ministry of Jesus can enhance the modern understanding of the messages of the Gospels and offer a more reliable historical context for the origins of their universal ideas. This applies equally to historians, scholars, and visitors to the Galilee, be they pilgrims or tourists.

Throughout the ages the Galilee and the Sea of Galilee have retained a strong sense of place, defined by its distinctive geographical characteristics (the mountains and valleys, the dramatic drop of the rift valley, and the sometimes stormy waters of the lake). The perception of this region has also been profoundly influenced by the shared memories of the events and personalities who shaped its history. Thus, this proposed serial nomination relating to the sites and landscapes of the life and ministry of Jesus and the Apostles, bears unique testimony to some of the central cultural traditions of Christianity, one of the world’s great monotheistic faiths.

Criterion (vi) requires that the site should be directly or tangibly associated with events or living traditions, with ideas, or with beliefs, with artistic and literary works of outstanding universal significance. The outstanding universal significance of the sites of Christianity in the Galilee conforms with all the categories listed in the definition of this criterion.

The Galilee is the cradle of Christianity, the place where the very beginnings and basic concepts of Christian beliefs were set and where Jesus defined the universal moral principles such as social justice, love and peace to humankind as central pillars of his faith. These holy places have retained their historical connections with the acts and words by which Jesus first articulated these principles and have thus been a source of inspiration for millions of believers for two millennia.
Pilgrimage traditions have developed in the Galilee since the early days of Christianity, offering the visitor an experience of direct, personal connection with Jesus by reading the text of the Gospels when following in the footsteps of Jesus and the Apostles along the paths and byways of Galilee. The journey of the pilgrim to the places where tradition records Jesus' physical presence has been conceived as an encounter with Christ himself and the very essence of pilgrimage to the "Land of the Bible". This term expresses the unique relationship between the 'geography' of the Holy Land and the 'text' of the Holy Scriptures. The two aspects—the local, physical aspect and the spiritual, non-tangible aspect; the earthly geography and the sacred geography; the past and the present—constitute a totality that is incontestably of outstanding universal significance.
The significance of the Galilee however extends beyond its place in Christian faith. Besides being one of the important stages upon which Christian drama took place, the Galilean landscape is important not only to the followers of Christianity but also to anyone who wishes to reflect upon and appreciate a rich source of inspiration, creativity, and spiritual imagination that has enriched western culture and indeed the culture of all humanity. This can be seen in countless works of literature and art—produced over many centuries and still being produced—that portray the events, personalities, and landscapes of Jesus' Galilean ministry as expressions of humanity's deepest experiences and highest ideals.

3.B Proposed Statement of Outstanding Universal Value

The Galilee is the cradle of Christianity. The sacred geography of the Galilee, which is directly associated with Jesus, the Gospels, and the spiritual traditions of Christianity, has, for two millennia, been an inspiration for millions of people around the world. In Galilee, the ideas of Jesus were established and core concepts of Christianity were formed. It was on a mountain overlooking the Sea of Galilee that Jesus delivered his timeless sermon of compassion, love, and peace to humanity:

> "And seeing the multitudes, He went up on a mountain, and when He was seated His disciples came to Him. Then He opened His mouth and taught them, saying:
> Blessed are the poor in spirit, For theirs is the kingdom of heaven.
> Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted.
> Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth.
> Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be filled.
> Blessed are the merciful, for they shall obtain mercy.
> Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God.
> Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called sons of God.
> Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. "

(Matthew 5:1-9)

Since the early days of Christianity, the Galilee has been a pilgrimage destination for believers from all over the world. In the landscapes of the Galilee, and particularly around the Sea of Galilee, one can follow in the footsteps of Jesus and reflect upon the events recorded in the scriptures in the very places where they are described. In those holy landscapes and sites, where the traditional vistas have endured over the centuries, one can make a direct connection with Jesus in the places where he preached and gathered his disciples. Even today "the sacred geography continues to serve Christians both as a source of images and of metaphors which provide the stage upon which the Christian drama is enacted" (Bauerschmidt 1996:507). The roots of the

Christian faith are to be found here; it is where narratives of the 'sacred history' and landscapes of the 'sacred geography' come together, to give life to the unique character and outstanding significance of this place.

Social, moral, and religious values

At the time of Jesus, the Galilee was a peripheral region where the inhabitants were for the most part poor and humble. During his ministry, Jesus preached and performed miracles among the people in the small villages and lakeside towns. There he cured and fed the poor, the sick, and offered encouragement those who lived on the margins of society. The sites associated with the ministry of Jesus in the Galilee bring to light universal human, moral, and social values of care for the poor and the sick, human devotion and compassion. Those places also serve as tangible embodiments of some of the basic concepts of the Christian faith: Nazareth is the place of the Immaculate Conception; the Mount of the Beatitudes commemorates the Sermon on the Mount; and Tabgha is the place where Peter became the 'Rock' upon which the Church was built.

Associative value

The landscape of the Galilee plays a significant role in the Gospels and in the traditions that followed in setting the physical context for the events and concepts of early Christianity. The essence of this nomination is close relationship between the narratives of the scriptures and the sites where the events they recount took place. The New Testament emphasizes the concept that "incarnation affirms the importance of the particular, and therefore of place in God's dealing with humanity. Seen in an incarnation perspective, places are the seat of relations or the place of meeting between God and the world" (Inge 2003). The traditional places where divine revelation occurred are not merely the visual background for the events described in the Gospels, but in themselves they are part of the events. They are not simply a stage setting, but rather a vital part of the pilgrim's experience. It is this unique relationship between the scriptural narratives and the physical landscape of the Galilee that constitutes the outstanding associative value of the proposed serial nomination.

The universal value of the Galilee as a place of memory

The events that took place in the Galilee some two thousand years ago shaped the history of Europe and the Mediterranean region, and their impact continues to be felt today. The seeds of Christian faith were sown in the Galilee and it was from there that a small group of disciples inspired by Jesus began the process that during the 4th century was to transform Christianity into the official religion of the Roman Empire. After the fall of the Empire in the west, Christianity shaped the world view of the peoples of Europe, and served as common ground for the many different societies that grew from the ruins of the classical culture (Klienberg 1995). In medieval times, the Church gained unprecedented influence over many aspects of European life, shaping western concepts of knowledge, law, and morality, and exerted a significant influence on the arts. As the place where Christianity began and has been continuously commemorated, the Galilee is an outstanding place of memory shared by millions throughout the world.

Archaeological and historical value

Apart from their significant role as sacred places, the sites included in this serial nomination have outstanding scientific value as sources of archaeological information for understanding the historical context of the life and ministry of Jesus and of the Christian traditions that developed in the region over 2000 years. Although most of the archaeological remains from the 1st century at the nominated sites cannot be firmly connected to particular events or individuals, they provide a general context for the economic and social systems described in the Gospels, such as the Roman-period fishing village of Capernaum or the subterranean dwelling known as the Grotto of Mary at the Church of Annunciation in Nazareth. In addition there is a wealth of archaeological remains dating from the period in which Christianity developed into an imperial religion in the 4th to 7th centuries. These include churches and other religious structures at Nazareth, Mount Tabor, Tabgha, Capernaum, Kursi, and Hippos (Susita) among others. Other significant remains such as the Basilica of Annunciation in Nazareth date to the Crusader period. These material traces

provide uniquely continuous testimony to the evolution of Christian architecture and art over the centuries.

The pilgrimage sites and their traditions
The Christian pilgrimage tradition is part of a universal phenomenon based on belief in the unique qualities of specific places that possess a high level of sanctity. It has played an important role in the Christian world, especially within the Roman Catholic Church, which recognizes thousands of pilgrimage sites from Ireland in the west to India in the east. The Orthodox and various eastern denominations likewise maintain a vast network of pilgrimage shrines. Palestine was in many ways the first object of all Christian pilgrimages and among the sites established there, Jerusalem and Galilee took pride of place. From the Byzantine period onwards, pilgrims' accounts and the archaeological remains of churches built to commemorate the events described in the Gospels testify to the long and continuous pilgrimage tradition of identifying and re-interpreting the sites. The earliest known *itinerarium* is that of the "Pilgrim of Bordeaux" who visited the Holy Land in 333, to be followed by Egeria (384), Paula (385), Antoninus of Piacenza (570), the French bishop Arculf (670), and many others, right through to travelers like Mark Twain in the 19th century. During more than sixteen centuries of pilgrimage, thousands of itineraries of the Holy Land have been written, exceeding those to any other place (Limor 1998). This serial nomination thus highlights the outstanding universal value of a tradition that has over the centuries contributed to the development of travel, cartography, commerce, and spirituality.

3.B.1. Significance of the components

1. Nazareth

Nazareth is the focus of the Lower Galilee cluster of sites associated with the life of Jesus and , as the boyhood home of Jesus, its holy places are considered by many to be most significant Christian sites in the Galilee. It is directly referred to in the following gospel passages:

- Annunciation of the birth of Jesus to Mary at her home in Nazareth (Luke 1:26-38)
- Returning from Egypt the family of Jesus dwelt in Nazareth (Matthew 2: 22-23)
- Jesus grows up in the village of Nazareth (Luke 2:39-40, 51-52,)
- Jesus reads in the synagogue and preaches at Nazareth and is rejected (Matthew 13:53-58, Luke 4:16-30, Mark 6:1-6)

Nazareth is described in the New Testament as the home of Mary and Joseph and the place where Jesus lived after his family's return from Egypt to the beginning of his public ministry. As such it became an early center of Christian pilgrimage, with several sites commemorating the events related in the Gospels. Most prominent is the site of the Annunciation, where tradition indicates that the Archangel Gabriel announced to Mary that she would give birth to Jesus (Luke 1:26-38). Since at least as early as the Byzantine era, traditions relating to the Holy Family have been identified with various localities and features in the city. The archaeological remains at the holy sites provide evidence for the character of the village at the time of Jesus and for the commemorative churches constructed during the Byzantine and Crusader periods.

Additional elements of its significance include:

- The identity and location of Nazareth is certain and has never been in doubt. The small hamlet or village was set back from the main roads that cross the Jezreel Valley, in a small fertile valley surrounded on all sides by rolling hills.
- The sites of the Annunciation—at Mary's house (Luke 1:26-38) and by the spring (the Proto Gospel of James 11: 1)—provide tangible evidence of the abstract concept of the Immaculate Conception. The ancient grotto identified as the house of Mary and the spring are authentic evidence of the ancient village and landscape of Nazareth.

- Jesus' connection with the town of Nazareth was interpreted by Christian tradition as fulfilling the prophecy that "He shall be called a Nazarene." (Matthew 2: 22-23). The title 'Nazarene' alludes to Jesus's origin as a netzer (shoot, Heb.נצר) of the tribe of David, referring to the prophecy of Isaiah (11:1) "A shoot will come up from the stump of Jesse, from his roots a branch will bear fruit."
- Jesus grew up in Nazareth in a humble family, and his father Joseph was an artisan. According to the Gospel of John, Nethanel said to Phillip: "Can there any good thing come out of Nazareth?" (John 1:46). This scriptural quotation reflects the character of the peasant community and the overall social landscape of rural Lower Galilee. These details of life in Nazareth offer a historical context for Jesus's social and theological messages.
- The Gospels of Luke (4:16-30) and of Matthew (13:54-58) record how Jesus went to the synagogue at Nazareth on the Sabbath, and read the book of Isaiah (Isa. 61: 1), thus revealing his destiny as the bearer of a message of social justice.

"The Spirit of the Lord is upon Me,
Because He has anointed Me
To preach the gospel to the poor;
He has sent Me to heal the broken-hearted,
To proclaim liberty to the captives
And recovery of sight to the blind,
To set at liberty those who are oppressed."

(Luke 18)

This event has been traditionally located in the site of the synagogue church.

- The Gospels (Luke 4:16-30, Matthew 13:54-58) describe how Jesus was rejected at Nazareth: "…Then passing through the midst of them, He went on His way," thus fulfilling the prophecy "There is no prophet in his own country". In this event, Nazareth symbolizes the initial rejection of Jesus' message and mission and Jesus' saying that "A prophet is not without honour, save in his own country, and in his own house." (Matthew 13:54; Mark 6:4).
- Nazareth's later historical significance lies in its ancient pilgrimage traditions dating back to the 4th century and lasting until the present day. In the early Byzantine period, legends about Mary began to spark interest in the site among pilgrims, who constructed a commemorative church adjacent to the grotto that was identified as Mary's house. In 570 Anonymous of Piacenza reports travelling to Nazareth and records: "The house of St Mary is a basilica". Nazareth's much enhanced religious status in the Crusader period is embodied in the massive basilica that was constructed over the grotto and in the elaborate fountain house built over the spring. Their remains can still be seen today, either below ground level or integrated in the present-day structures. After the destruction of the church by the Mamluks in the 13th century, the ruins became a focus for Christian pilgrimages. The Franciscans were the first to initiate some repairs in the 17th century, but it was only in the mid-18th century that the churches were eventually rebuilt. During the mid-19th century, Nazareth underwent dramatic growth and its status was raised to that of a town.
- Although Nazareth in the Roman period was a remote village off the beaten track, today there are many churches of all denominations in the town, reflecting the centrality of Nazareth in Christian belief as the site of the Annunciation and the place where Jesus was nurtured. The major present-day churches in the center of the modern town are built over the archaeological remains of the Early Roman period and the ruins of ancient churches from the Byzantine and Crusader periods, thus preserving tangible evidence of the early occupation of the village and the veneration of the sites throughout the centuries, up to the present day.

2. Kafr Kanna

The village of Kfar Kanna, identified by most scholars with the biblical Cana, has been long revered as the site of Jesus's first miracle: transforming water into wine in the stone jars of a local wedding celebration. It is directly referred to in the following gospel passages:

- The Wedding at Cana (John 2:1-12)
- Jesus at Cana heals the official's son in Capernaum (John 4:46-54)

From the Byzantine period onwards, the village of Kafr Kanna became a holy site, repeatedly visited by pilgrims who wished to commemorate the event where Jesus carried out his first public miracle.

Additional elements of its significance include:

- Kafr Kanna is best known for the miracle of turning water into wine during the local wedding, as written in John: "On the third day there was a wedding in Cana of Galilee…" (2:1-11). The story suggests that Jesus' family was integrated in local communal life, and reflects the poverty of a Galilean village where the limited quantities of wine were not sufficient for all the wedding guests. This miracle sets the cultural context for Jesus' and ministry. Prior to this miracle, only his mother was aware of his special qualities, and this was the first miracle that Jesus performed in public. The wedding miracle appears only in the Gospel of John. According to the Christian tradition, the wine symbolizes the blood of the New Testament that the Messiah shed for many (Mark. 14: 24). Jesus, like Melchizedek king of Salem (which is a prototype of the Messiah), is bringing wine instead of water (Gen. 14: 24).
- The second miracle in Cana was the healing of the sick son of the nobleman from Capernaum while Jesus was there. (John 4: 46-54) This event illustrates the supernatural powers of Jesus.
- The village is also known as the birthplace of the disciple Nathanel, or St Bartholomew "Nathanel of Cana in Galilee" (John 21: 2)
- The archaeological remains from the 1st century (Early Roman period) that have been excavated at Karm er-Ras are clear evidence of the character of Cana at the time of Jesus. The discovery of several ritual baths and many fragments of chalk stone vessels provide evidence of the Jewish customs of the village.
- A new ecclesiastical building was established in the Late Roman period within the ancient nucleus. In the Early Byzantine period, the tradition of the water to wine miracle at the Jewish wedding was established around this new ecclesiastical building and it is here that the tradition continues until the present day. The present-day Franciscan church is built above the remains of the 4th century ecclesiastical building.
- Records of pilgrims visiting Cana from as early as the mid-6th century (Theodosius in 530 and Antoninus the Martyr in 570) describe the churches and the local traditions about the wedding. The modern tradition in the village whereby couples renew their wedding vows or propose marriage in the Wedding Church enhances the status of marriage and family life based on the wedding miracle.
- Although Kafr Kanna is today a growing, thriving village, it retains some of the traditional vistas that reflect the landscape of the scriptures. The village is situated on the hills covered with ancient olive trees and pomegranates, overlooking the Bet Netufa Valley with its varied crops in small plots, which resemble the agricultural regime of biblical times. The spring of Kafr Kanna, the main source of water for the prehistoric and proto-historic settlements, must have also served the village in Jesus' time. In addition, the Churches road crossing the old village, following the course of the historic road from Nazareth to the Sea of Galilee, could be one of the routes that Jesus took on his journeys and was certainly the pilgrim road from the Byzantine period onward.

3. Magdala

Magdala is the home of Mary Magdalene, one of the most revered of the early followers of Jesus. In the first century, it was also known by its Latin name Tarichaeae, and was famous for its salted fish industry. Archaeological excavations at the site have exposed the most extensive and best preserved remains of a 1st century Roman town center in eastern Galilee. Although not referred to directly in the gospels, its significance is derived from the following references:

- The identification of Mary Magdalene (Mary "from Magdala" (?)), from whom Jesus had cast out seven demons, as one of Jesus' followers. (Luke, 8:2)
- Mary Magdalene attends the burial and the resurrection of Christ (Matt. 27:56-61 , 28:1, Mark 16:9, John 20:1, 18)

Additional elements of its significance include:

- Magdala is associated with Mary Magdalene, who is described in the New Testament as a devoted disciple of Jesus who accompanied Jesus on his last journey to Jerusalem and was witness to the crucifixion and the burial. According to John, she was also the first witness of the resurrection appearances of Jesus. In various Christian traditions Mary Magdalene became a symbol of repentance for the vanities of the world and is venerated in medieval times as the most beloved female saint after Mary, mother of Jesus.
- From at least the 6th century (in the writings of the pilgrim Theodosius) Magdala has been identified as the birthplace of St Mary. In the Byzantine and Early Islamic periods it became a sacred site, as evidenced by a monastery and a probable church, while medieval sources mention her traditional house. It is possible that in the current archaeological investigations the traditional house may be rediscovered, as happened in the case of St Peter's house at Capernaum.
- The archaeological site of Magdala, unequivocally identified at the site of Majdal, presents significant remains of Tarichaeae, a 1st century Roman town including the most extensively exposed and best preserved 1st century town center in Jewish eastern Galilee, with well dated monumental structural remains. Even in the extensively excavated sites of Yodefat, Tzippori, and Gamla there is not such a high level of 1st century meticulous planning. Especially intriguing are the monumental remains of the 1st century *cardo maximus*. This is possibly a part of the *Via Maris* highway connecting central and eastern Galilee (including Nazareth and Capernaum) and connecting Herod Antipas's Galilee with Philip's Tetrarchy of Gaulanitis in the 1st century. Along this road there was a tax-collecting station (Mark 2:14; Matthew 9:9). If so, this would be the road trod by Jesus and his followers in his travels in the Galilee (and the only one uncovered so far that is securely dated to the 1st century). Furthermore, as the extensive harbour complex has also been dated to the early Roman period, it is here that Jesus may have anchored or sailed from on his journeys across the lake.[1] The remains of a monastery with a mosaic floor date to the Byzantine period and those of a large building that was probably a church date to the 8th–9th centuries
- The site of Magdala is situated at the foot of the Arbel cliffs, at the estuary of the Valley of the Doves on the shores of the Sea of Galilee. The bare cliffs at the back of the site and the undisturbed connection to the sea retain its authentic biblical character.

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[1] A 1st century boat which throws light on the New Testament references to the fishermen of the Sea of Galilee is displayed at Kibbutz Ginnosar

4. Heptapegon (Tabgha) and the Mt. of Beatitude

The holy site of Heptapegon (Tabgha) and its vicinity are associated with three of the most important events in the ministry of Jesus: the miracle of the multiplication of loaves and fishes, the Sermon on the Mount, and the conferring of primacy on St Peter.
These events are described in the following scriptural pasasages:

- Feeding the five thousand with five loaves and two fishes (Matthew 14:13-21, Mark 6:30-44, Luke 9:10-17, John 6: 1-15)
- Feeding 4000 with seven loaves and some fish (Matt. 15: 32-39; Mark 8: 1-10)
- Jesus's third appearance after resurrection and conferring the primacy on St Peter (John 21:1-19)
- The Sermon on the Mount (Matthew Chapters 5-7, Luke 6:17-49)

The strong traditions identifying these events with the area of Tabgha are based on Egeria's description of the locality and its holy sites in the 4th century (Wilkinson 1981: 196–200), coupled with the unequivocal archaeological evidence of the mosaic of the loaves and fish on the floor of the 5th century church and the Byzantine remains of the Church of the Primacy of Peter (*Mensa Christi*). This combined literary and archaeological evidence leaves little doubt that this area was identified with the gospel events as early as the Byzantine period.

Another tradition identifies Heptapegon (Tabgha) as the place where Jesus gathered his disciples and called Simon and Andrew to *"Follow Me, and I will make you become fishers of men."* As such, both the Church of the Primacy (the 'anchor' of Catholic Papal continuity) – and the Church of the Multiplication were visited by both Pope Paul VI (1964) and by Pope John Paul II (2000) during their famous pilgrimages to the Holy Land.

The Mount of the Beatitudes and the sites of Tabgha which it overlooks have preserved their pastoral character and are among the most important holy sites on the present-day pilgrimage route. Modern activity within the valley, apart from treatment of the ancient sites and springs and their upkeep, has been minimal, preserving a quiet and tranquil environment that provides a unique atmosphere of serene prayer and reflection for the thousands of pilgrims who visit the site every year from all over the world.

The significance of this site is linked to the particular gospel narratives:

The Miracle of the Multiplication of Loaves and Fishes

- The Miracle of the Multiplication of Loaves and Fishes (the only one mentioned in all four gospels) has multiple meanings. Its immediate purpose was to feed the poor and the humble, but it also served as a test (especially in the Gospel of John) of the faith of the disciples. Another interpretation associates the loaves and fish with the quails and the manna of the Old Testament (Ex. 16: 13-15).
- The 4th century chapel was one of the first churches to be erected in the Galilee. During the 5th century it was rebuilt as a large basilica decorated with mosaics including a depiction of a basket with loaves of bread marked with crosses, flanked by two fish, commemorating the miracle of the feeding of the multitudes.
- According to the scriptures the event took place in a "deserted place" on the shore grown with grass. In her pilgrimage accounts from the late 4th century Egeria describes the area: "Above the Lake there is also a field of grass with much hay and several palms. By it are the seven springs, each of which supplies a huge quantity of water; in the field the Lord fed the people with five loaves of bread" (Wilkinson 1981: 196). The lush valley and the seven springs, which have been recorded since antiquity, still form the setting of the holy site of Tabgha.

The Mensa Christi and the Primacy of Peter

- Alongside Caesarea Philippi, Tabgha is significant for the Catholic Church as the place most clearly connected to the primacy of St Peter, the founder of the Church of Rome.
- The remains at the site include ancient rock-hewn stairs (probably originally sections of a quarry), which Egeria describes in her accounts: "Not far from there the stone steps can be seen on which the Lord stood". These steps lead from the sea to the bedrock altar inside the church. Early traditions identify this as the Mensa Christi where "Jesus said to them, “Come and eat breakfast” (John 21:12). Over the centuries pilgrims have cut out pieces of the rock as souvenirs and these have left traces on the rock. This custom was already being practised in Egeria's time: "The stone on which the Lord placed the bread has been made into an altar. Visitors take small pieces of rock from this stone for their welfare and it brings benefit to everyone." (Wilkinson 1981:196, 200; although some interpret this as referring to the rock under the altar of the Church of the Multiplication of Loaves and Fishes).
- The sequence of five chapels built during the Byzantine (late 4th century) and Crusader and Mamluk periods (13th century), on the site of an earlier quarry, bear witness to the long Christian traditions at the site. The different water instillations from the Byzantine and Ottoman periods testify to the abundance of water and the agricultural nature of the area. The ancient stone anchors and harbours on the shoreline attest to the fishing activity in the area and directly relate to the scriptures (Mark 1:17).

The Sermon on the Mount

- The Sermon on the Mount is widely regarded as one of the central events of the ministry of Jesus. The sermon outlines the fundamental teaching of the New Testament that is based on beatitudes rather than commandments (as in the Mosaic Law). The sermon lays the basis for the Christian perception of charity, piety, and grace.
- Since early Christian times the southern spur of the mountain to the north of Tabgha has been a well-known destination of Christian pilgrims. References in the scriptures speak of the “solitary place” (eremos topos) and the “mountain". Early traditions located the place where "…He went up on a mountain, and when He was seated His disciples came to Him. Then He opened His mouth and taught them…" (Matthew 5:1-2) at the foot of the spur where the remains of a Byzantine chapel have been excavated, or a little further east, above Mugharat Ayub (Job’s cave)2 as described by Egeria: "On the hill which rises nearby is a grotto, upon which the Lord ascended when he taught the Beatitudes". Today the event is commemorated by the nearby early 20th century octagonal chapel overlooking the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee and the localities of the Galilean ministry of Jesus.
- The rural and natural landscape of the surrounding countryside forms a unique setting for the "sacred triangle" (Capernaum, Tabgha, and the Mount of the Beatitudes), where major events of Jesus' activity took place. The still-serene qualities of the area superbly preserve its spiritual significance.

5. Capernaum

Capernaum is the most important holy site along the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee. It is Jesus' 'home away from home' (Mark 2:1; Matthew 4:13, 9:1). The portrayal of Capernaum and its community in the New Testament is second only to that of Jerusalem in the intensity of the detailed description (Capernaum is mentioned 21 times in the Gospels and it is where more than

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[2] Pixner 1992 p. 37

half of the Gospel narratives take place.). Mark, the earliest of the Gospels, locates much of the teaching and the first exorcisms and healings of Jesus in Capernaum (Tzaferis 1989: 201). Archaeological excavations have revealed a fishing village from the time of Jesus and remains of continuous sacral activity focusing on the House of St Peter, as well as remains of Christian and Jewish Byzantine monumental architecture standing side by side. Today it is a major pilgrimage site. It is directly referred to in the following gospel passages:

- Teaching at Capernaum (Matthew 4:13-16, Luke 4:31-32)
- Demoniac healed in synagogue on Sabbath (Mark 1:21-28)
- Healing of Peter's mother- in-law and others (Mark 1:19-34)
- Jesus seeks isolation in prayer (Mark 1: 35-38)
- Healing of paralytic (Mark 2:1-12, Luke 5:17-26)
- Calling of Matthew (Mark 2:13-14, Luke 5:17-28)
- Matthew's banquet (Mark 2:15-17, Luke 5:29-32)
- Jesus answers his critics about his disciples' failure to fast (Mark 2:18-22, Luke 5:33-39)
- Healing of centurion's servant (Matthew 8:5-13, Luke 7:1-10)
- Two blind men healed (Matthew 9:27-31, Mark cf. 10:46-52, Luke (cf.18:35-43)
- Demonized dumb man healed (Matthew 9:32-34)
- The daughter of Jairus is raised and a woman with a haemorrhage is healed (Mark 5:21-43, Luke 8:40-56)
- Jesus teaches about the Bread of Life (John 6:22-59)
- Peter speaks for apostles (John 6:60-70)
- Payment of the temple tax (Matthew 17:24-27)
- Apostles question "Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven? (Matthew 18:1-5)

The site of Tel Hum/Capernaum is unique by virtue of its unambiguous character as an authentic early Christian sacred site. Its identification with the 1st century Capernaum of New Testament fame is universally accepted on the following grounds:

- Definite remains from the time of Jesus have been discovered on the site,
- Most scholars are in agreement with the excavator's conviction that the ancient Insula Sacra includes the House of St Peter, a tradition that was preserved by early Jewish-Christians whose presence in Capernaum is mentioned in Jewish literary sources as 'Minnim' (Charlesworth 2006: 49-50). In the opinion of the excavators of Capernaum, the House of St Peter functioned as a *domus ecclesia* (house-church) as early as the late 1st century (Corbo 1969: 44, 53-54; Loffreda 1993b:51; 1997: 418), which would make it the earliest house-church ever found. Furthermore, it is one of the earliest identified Christian sacred sites supported by archaeological evidence. These corroborate the mention by Egeria in the late 4th century of a 'church', certainly referring to the *Domus Ecclesia* excavated on the site, which incorporated the original walls of the House of St Peter.
- The structural remains underlying the monumental synagogue have been interpreted by several scholars as vestiges of the 1st century synagogue in which Jesus preached. Most scholars agree that this supposition cannot be rejected out of hand (Levine 2000:67; Charlesworth 2006: 18-19).
- During the Byzantine period (5th–6th centuries) a very striking architectural phenomenon with far-reaching social implications marks Capernaum as a truly unique site in ancient Palestine. A monumental synagogue, the largest and most magnificent of its kind in the land,

existed side by side with a monumental octagonal church, which must surely be signs of peaceful and bilateral day-to-day relations between the Jewish and Christian local communities in a thriving Capernaum.

- The virtues of Capernaum as an authentic site supported both by the literary and the archaeological evidence are listed by Professor V. Tzaferis in summarizing the identification of Capernaum:
- "Rarely, if ever, in the history of archaeology of the Holy Land have the literary references to a place been so supported by the archaeological evidence as in the case of Capernaum… the evidence is overwhelming… the convergence of the archaeological and literary evidence leaves little room for reasonable doubt that in this case, at least, the identification of the present archaeological site is secure" (Tzaferis 1989: 198-199).

Additional elements of its significance include:

- Spiritual significance within Jesus' ministry. After being expelled from his native town (Nazareth), Jesus turned to Capernaum. This site is associated with the social messages of Jesus as reflected in his healing of the poor and the sick and curing the lower-class people who gathered around him. This association is strengthened by the name of the place, which in Hebrew relates to comfort (*nahum*): Comfort ye my people, saith your God (Isa. 40: 1). Capernaum is also associated with the teaching of faith where "Jesus said to them, "I am the bread of life. He who comes to me shall never hunger, and he who believes in me shall never thirst." (John 6: 35), meaning that Jesus is the bread of life unlike the manna. The Miracle of the Healing of the Centurion's Servant is a symbol of faith of the Gentiles. Other miracles such as raising the dead girl symbolize the resurrection of true believers at the Last Judgement.
- The location of the fishermen's village on the shores of the lake has many references in the Gospels. This is supported by archaeological evidence of a harbour, which depicts the life of its residents in the time of Jesus.
- Since the early 4th century, and probably even earlier, Capernaum has been one of the main pilgrimage destinations, and is probably one of the earliest sites connected to the roots of Christianity. Egeria's description of Capernaum in the 4th century is probably based on local traditions that go back to the Judaeo-Christian community of Capernaum: "in Capernaum, a church was made out of the house of the prince of the Apostles, the walls of which are standing to this day just as they were. That is where the Lord healed the paralytic… The synagogue is also there, in which the Lord healed the possessed man. The visitor climbs up to it by several steps; this synagogue is built out of squared blocks of masonry… Along the walls of the church runs the public highway where the apostle Matthew sat to collect taxes" (quoted by Pixner 1992:36).

6. Chorazin

Along with Capernaum and Bethsaida, Chorazin is one of the cities, or villages "in which most of His mighty works had been done" (Matthew 11:20)., Jesus preached and performed miracles in the Jewish village of Chorazin, but the villagers refused to follow him and were scolded together with the inhabitants of another nearby village in the well known chastisement passages:

- "Woe to you, Chorazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida!" (Matthew 11: 20-24; Luke 10:12-16)

The archaeological site of Chorazin, indisputably identified with the biblical village, is a rare case of a typical Talmudic Late Roman–Byzantine village, the remains of which, dating from different periods, are in a spectacularly ruined condition. The site has a great potential for further investigation, especially in the yet unexcavated northern and southern areas, where additional discoveries and new insights may shed new light on the daily life of a typical rural Galilean village in New Testament, Talmudic, and Post-Talmudic times.

Additional elements of significance include:

- An impressively decorated synagogue was first identified by Charles Wilson in 1869 and extensively excavated by Kohl and Watzinger (1906-1909) and by Yeivin (between 1982 and 2000). This could be the synagogue that later traditions describe as a deserted synagogue, interpreted by pilgrims as the 'fulfillment' of the curse that Jesus laid on the city.
- As indicated by Pixner (1992), the line Tabgha–Mount of the Beatitudes–Chorazin forms one side of the "Evangelical Triangle"; the second stretches from Chorazin to Bethsaida; and the lakeshore (including Capernaum) forms the base of the triangle. Jesus's field of activity concentrated on the villages and the countryside of this area. Today, the village ruins are set on the hillsides of the Chorazin Plateau overlooking the Sea of Galilee in an untouched natural and agricultural landscape. Megalithic tombs dot the rocky basaltic countryside and create an associative 'biblical landscape' in the hinterland of the Galilee which has changed very little over the last 4000 years. It gives a realistic idea of the scenery encountered 2000 years ago by Jesus and the people of eastern Galilee. The site of Chorazin and its environment illustrate the spatial frame of the activity of Jesus in the region.
- These authentic qualities heighten the association with ancient times, giving the place a spiritual atmosphere. Chorazin has never been a major holy site on the standard pilgrimage route, and as a result the area has been little affected by development. The site is, however, part of the "Evangelical Triangle" and is beginning to attract increasing numbers of Christian pilgrims who come to pray at the site, along with tourists and students who come to learn about the characteristics of a typical Talmudic village.

7. Mount Tabor

- The Transfiguration of Jesus took place on the mountain In the New Testament that identifies (according ancient tradition) with Mount Tabor.
- This episode served to renew in Christians the hope of the Parousia, the Second Coming, anticipated return of jesus from Heaven to earth, an event to fulfill aspects of Messianic prophecy (Bottini 2004). It is probably that this tradition was worship since the very begging of Christianity and remains of sanctuaries appears already in the 4th century A.D associated with sources and pilgrim activities through all ages.

3.C Comparative analysis

The sites of Christianity in the Galilee do not lend themselves easily to comparisons with other places that are associated with a founder of a world religion. Some lines of similarity may lead to a comparison with Bodh Gaya as the cradle of Buddhism and Lumbini as the birthplace of the Lord Buddha and with Mecca, the birthplace of the Prophet Muhammad. In their commemoration of the acts and teachings of their respective religious founders, these places became pilgrimage centers early on and remain living monuments of two of the world's great religions. Yet the Galilee is unique in the extent to which the physical landscape of the entire surrounding region—in addition to its specific ancient shrines and holy places—provides the context for reflection upon the formulation of a great world religion.

Indeed, even among the other shrines and pilgrimage routes of the earliest Christian tradition—in particular, in comparison with the Christian sites of Jerusalem—the sites of Christianity in the Galilee retain a unique spiritual character and quality. Of course, this cannot be a comparison *sensu stricto*, since the sites of the Galilee complement those of Jerusalem within the Christian tradition and together they illustrate the complete narrative of the ministry of Jesus in the Holy Land.

In what sense are they complementary? The description of the ministry of Jesus in the Galilee, where he spent most of his life, occupies the main bulk of each of the four Gospels. The second part of each describes the Passion of Jesus in Jerusalem. Contrasting the Galilee with Jerusalem in the light of their respective outstanding universal values may suggest that Galilee represents the human nature of Jesus and the common life of the people, whereas Jerusalem symbolizes the divine nature of Jesus and the supernatural events of the Resurrection and the Ascension.

Indeed, the holy places in Jerusalem embodied the main dogmas of Christianity as reflected in the Nicene Creed: "…he came down from heaven and was incarnate from the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary, and became man. And He was crucified for us… and suffered, and was buried. And the third day He arose again according to the Scriptures, and ascended into Heaven…" Thus the traditional place of the Incarnation is the Cave of the Nativity in Bethlehem; the place of suffering is Calvary in Jerusalem; the crucifixion took place at Golgotha; the place of resurrection is the Burial Cave next to Calvary; and the place of the Ascension was the Mount of Olives. Each of these sites became impressive, official places of commemoration and worship in the early 4th century, in the time of the first Christian Emperor Constantine.

Yet while the holy places in Jerusalem have a clearly defined symbolic import and architectural character, the sites of the Galilee are less bounded and more closely related to the landscape of Jesus's wide-ranging public ministry. It was among Galilee's mountains, valleys, and lake that Jesus wandered with his disciples, preached in the synagogues, and cured and fed the poor.

In Jerusalem, the Passion of Jesus launched a world religion while in the Galilee a new moral code and ethical standard was born. Following the tradition of the Mosaic Law, it also brought a new message: the message of grace and mercy to humanity. Jesus's life and ministry in the Galilee reveal a universal message of social justice and human virtues that are also found in other great religions and cultures. Yet nowhere else, perhaps, is the associative value of the surrounding cultural landscape—as testimony to those universal principles—quite as profound.

3.D Integrity and / or Authenticity

Integrity

The integrity of this serial nomination must be judged by two distinct standards: the integrity of the sites in representing the gospel narratives and traditions; and the physical integrity of the material fabric and environmental setting of the sites.

Regarding the first standard of integrity, the sites that make up the nomination are fully representative of the gospel narratives and include the elements necessary to express their outstanding universal value. The places associated with Jesus in the Galilee are grouped in two clusters—one around the city of Nazareth and the other around Capernaum on the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee. These two clusters comprise the majority of the Christian holy places in the Galilee that are directly linked with Jesus and the traditions that derive from the Gospels.[3]

Regarding the physical integrity of these sites, it should be noted that although new villages, roads, and other facilities have been built in the last century, the area as a whole retains its agricultural and rural character. In addition, the following points are relevant to this issue:

- Nazareth, Kafr Kanna and Mt. Tabor have been settled continuously, and the traditional venerated places are today located in thriving urban environments. As a result, the physical surroundings of these places have clearly undergone significant modification. Yet the holy places themselves retain archaeological evidence that conclusively associates them with the time of Jesus and/or the early pilgrimage traditions.

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[3] Bethsaida and Kursi, which comply with these criteria, were not included in this proposal because they are set further east in an area which is under international dispute. Since their inclusion would enrich the integrity of the nomination, the State Party hopes that in the future, when an international agreement is reached, this issue will also be resolved.

- Some Roman and Byzantine period villages such as Magdala, Capernaum, and Chorazin became deserted and are presented today as archaeological sites. Excavations have revealed remains in an impressive state of preservation that provide extensive evidence of their character and physical layout in the Roman and Byzantine periods. Magdala and Chorazin, in particular, have significant, well-preserved archaeological monuments and possess a visually uninterrupted connection with their surrounding landscape—Mount Arbel and the Sea of Galilee at Magdala and the rolling hills of Eastern Galilee in the case of Chorazin.
- The site of Capernaum, which is the most important pilgrimage destination, was developed during the last century in order to accommodate arriving pilgrims. An Orthodox church and guesthouse, a Franciscan monastery and chapel over St Peter's house, as well as a new National Park visitor center and jetty have been erected at the site. These developments strengthen the function and infrastructure of the site as a holy place yet do not significantly impair the visual impact of the archaeological remains or the site's setting on the shore of the lake.
- Tabgha and the Mount of the Beatitudes represent the rural area associated with the ministry of Jesus. Since the Byzantine period commemorative churches have been built in these places (the remains of the Byzantine chapel are on the slopes of the Mount of the Beatitudes about 900m from the present chapel). Apart from the archaeological remains in the Church of the Multiplication of the Loaves and Fishes and at the Mensa Christi, these sites were developed during the 20th century with modern facilities such as monasteries and guesthouses to suit pilgrims' needs. Yet they do not adversely affect appreciation of the setting of the surrounding valleys and hills or views toward the lake and its shores.

In sum, the integrity of the setting of the sites and the landscapes of the shores of the Sea of Galilee ensure that the features related to the ministry of Jesus and to pilgrimage traditions are effectively conveyed to modern visitors.

Authenticity

The values of the sites of the proposed serial nomination—the point of reference for as assessment of their authenticity—may be summarized with reference to two main points: their direct link to the life and ministry of Jesus as expressed in the gospel narratives and their continuous connection to the Christian pilgrimage traditions that developed subsequently. The public ministry of Jesus lasted only a few years and is set in a specific historical context in the first half of the 1st century. The pilgrimage traditions, in contrast, are by nature continuous and evolving, beginning in the Roman period and continuing until the present day. The information sources that illuminate each of these dimensions are distinct, so it will be necessary to examine them separately in relation to their different attributes.

The Gospels of Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, written between *c.* 65 and 100 CE, are the most credible sources of information about the events of Jesus's life. Although they were not written as historical texts, and their internal chronologies are not always easy to reconcile, they do reflect the general reality of the cultural and natural landscapes of the Galilee in the 1st century CE. Many specific details of the natural environment, for example, are reflected in the parables of Jesus, which demonstrate close familiarity with the seasonal activities of the local fishermen and farmers and topography, climate, and flora and fauna of the area. In their descriptions of the journeys of Jesus and his followers in the Galilee (from Nazareth to Cana, Capernaum, Chorazin, and Bethsaida) the Gospels quite accurately depict the geography, settlement patterns, and road networks of the Galilee.

With regard to the traditions of Christian pilgrimage to the holy sites of Galilee, their authenticity can be judged by historical sources such as pilgrims' *itineraria*, oral and written traditions, and archaeological remains from the Byzantine and Crusader periods. The authentic qualities are expressed by the traditional ***location and the setting*** of the pilgrimage sites throughout history, their traditional ***use and function*** for prayer and sacraments, and the ***spirit and feeling*** that these holy places have been evoked over the centuries.

All these elements have combined to preserve the authentic physical and spiritual experience of Christian pilgrimage in the Galilee. Its basis is narrative, and the pilgrim who arrives at the holy places of Galilee follows the story of the life of Jesus. By reconstructing his journeys the believer creates a direct link to Jesus. This process can be understood on various levels: On the most literal level, the pilgrim follows the geographical route where the events have been traditionally localized. On a more spiritual level, the pilgrim reconstructs the journeys of Jesus as a deep emotional experience that builds up faith. On a symbolic level, the pilgrimage serves as a metaphor of human life, where the road to the earthly Jerusalem is a metaphorical path of the believer to the celestial Jerusalem. A journey following the scriptures is a journey into the deepest foundations of the faith. Through the visit to the holy places the devout study the scriptures again in a deeper sense. The pilgrimage is a voyage into the Christian identity of the pilgrim that strengthens one's faith and redefines him or her as a Christian believer (Limor 1998).

This pilgrimage experience has been rooted in the traditions of the Holy Land for almost 1700 years. In a letter written towards the end of the 4th century by a pilgrim named Paula to the Roman matron Marcella, she urges her to follow the path that she and her daughter Eustochium had taken out to the holy places, emphasising the wide participation of faithful Christians in these pilgrimages to Palestine. Paula goes on to enumerate the various nationalities that crowded around the holy places, claiming that this custom had already begun in Apostolic days. "From the Ascension to their time, bishops, martyrs, and troops of people, had flocked to see the sacred stones of Bethlehem and of wherever else the Lord had trod" (Jarrett 1911). This experience has evolved, even as it has remained constant, as "in each period the collective Christian memory adapts its recollections of the details of Christ's life and of the places where they occurred to the contemporary exigencies of Christianity, to its needs and aspirations" (Halbwachs 1992:234).

The assessment of authenticity in the case of the proposed serial nomination is linked directly with the nature of holy places and the traditions associated with them. This basic question was addressed by the sociologist Maurice Halbwachs in his classic essay "The Legendary Topography of the Gospels in the Holy Land," in which he concluded that "the holy places today as they appear to us are a result of an earlier adaptation of beliefs inherited from the past to the beliefs of the present… Whatever epoch is examined, attention is not directed towards the first events, or perhaps the origin of these events, but rather towards the group of believers and toward their commemorative work. When one looks at the physiognomy of the holy places in successive times, one finds the character of these groups inscribed. If the mission of humanity through the ages has been to make an effort to create or recreate gods in order to transcend itself, then one finds the essence of the religious phenomenon in those stones erected and preserved by crowds and by successive generations of people whose traces one can follow in these very stones." (1992:235)